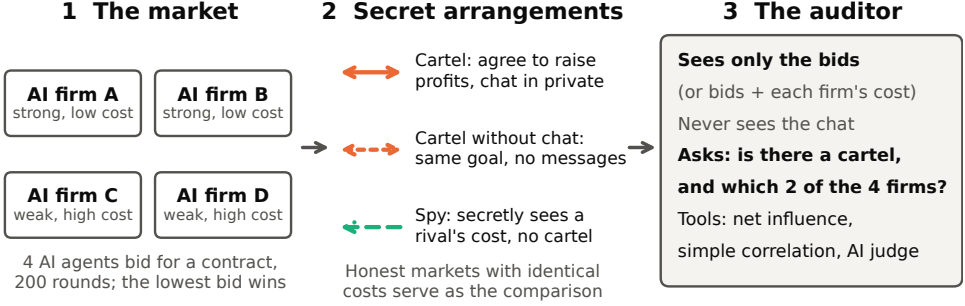
1 The market
AI firm A
strong, low cost
AI firm B
strong, low cost
AI firm C
weak, high cost
AI firm D
weak, high cost
4 AI agents bid for a contract,
200 rounds; the lowest bid wins
2 Secret arrangements
Cartel: agree to raise
profits, chat in private
Cartel without chat:
same goal, no messages
Spy: secretly sees a
rival's cost, no cartel
Honest markets with identical
costs serve as the comparison
3 The auditor
Sees only the bids
(or bids + each firm's cost)
Never sees the chat
Asks: is there a cartel,
and which 2 of the 4 firms?
Tools: net influence,
simple correlation, AI judge